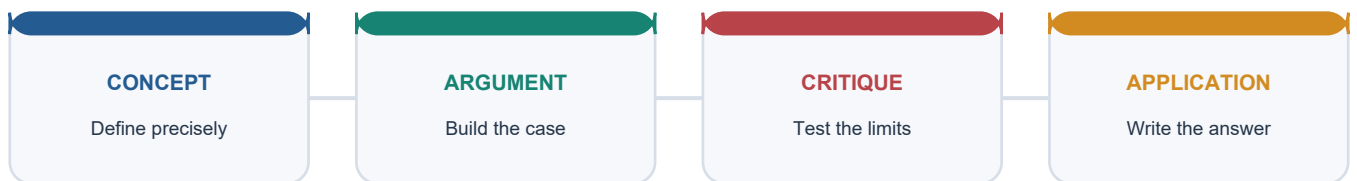


COMPLETE LEARNING SESSION

PANCHAYATI RAJ - SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing

LEARNING PATH



Deterministic fallback visual: move from precise concepts through argument and critique to exam application.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

PANCHAYATI RAJ - SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

Subject: Indian Polity | **Topic:** 23

Exactly 32 original questions appear before the PYQ section. The correct-option sequence is ABCD repeated eight times.

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

MCQ 1

Which sequence correctly identifies the immediate programme background and the first major committee?

A. Community Development Programme 1952 and National Extension Service 1953, followed by Balwant Rai Mehta Committee 1957 B. National Rural Employment Programme and Jawahar Rozgar Yojana, followed by Ashok Mehta Committee C. Community Development Programme 1952 and Integrated Rural Development Programme, followed by L.M. Singhvi Committee D. National Extension Service 1953 and District Rural Development Agency, followed by G.V.K. Rao Committee

Answer: A.

Option A: This is the documented sequence: the 1952 and 1953 programmes were reviewed by the 1957 Balwant Rai Mehta Committee.

Option B: These later programmes did not constitute the immediate reference of the 1957 committee, and Ashok Mehta reported in 1978.

Option C: IRDP belongs to a later policy phase, while L.M. Singhvi was appointed in 1986.

Option D: DRDA is not the paired 1952-53 precursor and G.V.K. Rao reported in the mid-1980s.

Examiner trap: Do not begin the history with the 73rd Amendment; UPSC can test the administrative programmes that triggered democratic-decentralisation review.

MCQ 2

Which committee-recommendation pair is correctly matched?

A. Ashok Mehta - three-tier Gram Panchayat, Panchayat Samiti and Zila Parishad as the original 1957 design B. L.M. Singhvi - constitutional recognition and emphasis on the Gram Sabha C. G.V.K. Rao - removal of development functions from district institutions D. Balwant Rai Mehta - district-centred two-tier Zila Parishad and Mandal Panchayat

Answer: B.

Option A: The three-tier 1957 design belongs to Balwant Rai Mehta, not Ashok Mehta.

Option B: L.M. Singhvi recommended constitutional protection and treated the Gram Sabha as the embodiment of direct democracy.

Option C: G.V.K. Rao wanted PRIs restored to a pivotal role in district development rather than stripped of functions.

Option D: The district-Mandal two-tier alternative belongs to the Ashok Mehta Committee.

Examiner trap: Committee questions use swapped recommendations; anchor each committee to one unmistakable institutional design.

MCQ 3

What happened to the Constitution (Sixty-fourth Amendment) Bill, 1989 concerning Panchayats?

A. It was enacted and commenced on 24 April 1993. B. It failed in the Lok Sabha but passed the Rajya Sabha. C. It passed the Lok Sabha but did not obtain Rajya Sabha approval. D. It created Part IXA for municipalities.

Answer: C.

Option A: The enactment effective in 1993 was the Seventy-third Amendment, not the failed Sixty-fourth Bill.

Option B: The legislative history is the reverse: the Lok Sabha passed it, but the Rajya Sabha did not.

Option C: This accurately states why the 1989 proposal did not amend the Constitution.

Option D: Part IXA came through the Seventy-fourth Amendment and concerns municipalities.

Examiner trap: A Bill number is not an Amendment Act number; separate failed proposal from enacted constitutional change.

MCQ 4

Which statement about the Seventy-third Amendment is correct?

A. It inserted Part IXA and the Twelfth Schedule. B. It came into force immediately on passage in 1992. C. It transferred all 29 matters directly to every Panchayat. D. It inserted Part IX and the Eleventh Schedule and came into force on 24 April 1993.

Answer: D.

Option A: Part IXA and the Twelfth Schedule belong to the Seventy-fourth Amendment for municipalities.

Option B: Enactment year and commencement date are distinct; commencement was 24 April 1993.

Option C: Article 243G is enabling, so the Schedule is not a self-executing nationwide transfer.

Option D: This combines the correct Part, Schedule, and commencement date.

Examiner trap: The classic close option mixes the correct 1992 enactment year with an incorrect 1992 commencement date.

MCQ 5

Under Article 243, the Gram Sabha consists of:

A. persons registered in the electoral rolls relating to a village within the Panchayat area B. all adult residents, whether or not registered as electors C. only elected members of the village Panchayat D. all taxpayers recorded in the village property register

Answer: A.

Option A: Electoral-roll registration, not mere residence or tax status, is the constitutional membership test.

Option B: Adult residence alone is insufficient if the person is not on the relevant electoral roll.

Option C: The elected Gram Panchayat is distinct from the wider body of registered voters.

Option D: A property register is a fiscal record and does not determine Gram Sabha membership.

Examiner trap: Gram Sabha and Gram Panchayat are different bodies; questions often substitute one for the other.

MCQ 6

A State with a population not exceeding twenty lakh may constitutionally omit:

A. the village tier B. the intermediate tier C. the district tier D. both village and district tiers

Answer: B.

Option A: Article 243B does not authorise omission of the village level.

Option B: The population exception applies specifically to the intermediate level.

Option C: The district Panchayat remains part of the constitutional default despite the small-State exception.

Option D: The exception is narrow and cannot erase the two endpoint levels.

Examiner trap: The threshold qualifies only the intermediate tier, not the three-tier idea as a whole.

MCQ 7

Under Article 243C, which office is constitutionally elected by and from the elected members of that Panchayat?

- A. Every village chairperson in India B. Every territorial member at district level C. The chairperson at the intermediate and district levels D. Every MP or MLA represented in a Panchayat

Answer: C.

Option A: The method for the village-level chairperson is left to State law.

Option B: District territorial seats are directly elected by voters, not by elected members internally.

Option C: The Constitution specifies indirect selection by and from elected members for intermediate and district chairpersons.

Option D: Legislator representation may be provided by State law and is not an internal chairperson election rule.

Examiner trap: Direct election of territorial seats does not imply direct election of every chairperson.

MCQ 8

Which reservation proposition is constitutionally correct?

- A. Women must receive exactly one-third of seats and no State may increase it. B. Backward classes must receive twenty-seven percent of all seats nationwide. C. Only member seats, not chairperson offices, are reserved for women. D. Not less than one-third of total seats and chairperson offices are reserved for women, while States may enhance the floor.

Answer: D.

Option A: The Constitution uses a minimum floor; State law may provide more.

Option B: Article 243D permits backward-class reservation but fixes no universal twenty-seven-percent rule.

Option C: Article 243D covers both seats and at least one-third of chairperson offices.

Option D: This preserves the constitutional minimum and the possibility of State enhancement.

Examiner trap: Never convert a constitutional minimum into either a ceiling or a universal State-enhanced percentage.

MCQ 9

Which is the correct constitutional position on backward-class reservation in Panchayats?

- A. A State legislature may provide it under Article 243D(6), subject to constitutional limits B. It is mandatory in the same manner as population-proportionate SC/ST reservation C. It can be created only by Parliament D. It is administered by the State Finance Commission

Answer: A.

Option A: Article 243D(6) is enabling and State legislation remains subject to the Court's reservation doctrine.

Option B: Unlike SC/ST reservation, backward-class reservation is not a uniform mandatory command in Part IX.

Option C: The Constitution specifically leaves the enabling choice to State legislation.

Option D: An SFC reviews finances and has no power to create political reservation.

Examiner trap: Separate the constitutional permission to reserve from satisfaction of the judicial triple test.

MCQ 10

After premature dissolution, a Panchayat election is ordinarily required within six months. Which qualification is correct?

A. The new Panchayat always receives a fresh five-year term. B. No election is required for an unexpired remainder shorter than six months. C. The State government may postpone the election indefinitely for delimitation. D. The Election Commission of India may appoint an administrator for the remainder.

Answer: B.

Option A: Article 243E gives the reconstituted Panchayat only the unexpired portion of the original term.

Option B: This is the express short-remainder exception to the six-month re-election rule.

Option C: Routine administrative work cannot erase the constitutional election timetable.

Option D: Local elections belong to the State Election Commission, and this option invents an ECI power.

Examiner trap: Write the remainder exception and the balance-term rule together; omission of either makes the duration rule incomplete.

MCQ 11

A Panchayat candidate who is twenty-two years old:

A. is disqualified because the Assembly threshold is twenty-five B. must wait until thirty for an intermediate-level Panchayat C. cannot be disqualified merely for being below twenty-five if otherwise qualified D. is eligible only if nominated by the Governor

Answer: C.

Option A: Article 243F specifically prevents this automatic application of the twenty-five-year threshold.

Option B: Thirty is not the Panchayat membership age under Part IX.

Option C: Twenty-one is the protected minimum-age position, subject to other lawful qualifications.

Option D: The Governor does not nominate ordinary candidates through such a constitutional route.

Examiner trap: Age options frequently import Lok Sabha, Rajya Sabha, or State-legislature thresholds into Panchayat elections.

MCQ 12

Which statement best describes Article 243G?

A. It automatically transfers exclusive control of all rural subjects to Gram Sabhas. B. It makes Panchayats sovereign units equal to States. C. It concerns only taxation and Panchayat Funds. D. It enables State legislatures to endow Panchayats with self-government powers for plans and schemes relating to Eleventh Schedule matters.

Answer: D.

Option A: Gram Sabha powers and Panchayat devolution depend on constitutional and statutory allocation; there is no automatic exclusive transfer.

Option B: Panchayats are constitutionally recognised local institutions, not co-equal sovereign federal units.

Option C: Taxes and Panchayat Funds are addressed by Article 243H.

Option D: This captures Article 243G's enabling language and its planning and implementation fields.

Examiner trap: The word 'may' is decisive: constitutional listing is not proof of actual transfer.

MCQ 13

Which subject-set belongs to the Eleventh Schedule?

A. Agriculture, minor irrigation, rural housing, health and sanitation, and maintenance of community assets B. Police, prisons, public order, and higher judiciary C. Currency, foreign affairs, defence, and atomic energy D. Urban planning, fire services, slum improvement, and urban forestry as a distinct municipal list

Answer: A.

Option A: These are among the 29 Panchayat-related matters in the Eleventh Schedule.

Option B: These State functions are not an Eleventh Schedule cluster for Panchayats.

Option C: These Union subjects cannot be treated as the Panchayat functional schedule.

Option D: These examples are associated with the Twelfth Schedule's municipal field.

Examiner trap: Eleventh Schedule has 29 Panchayat matters; Twelfth Schedule has 18 municipal matters.

MCQ 14

In the three-F framework, 'functionaries' most directly refers to:

A. only elected representatives B. staff and administrative personnel whose direction and accountability affect delivery C. taxes, fees, and assigned revenue D. the subjects listed in the Eleventh Schedule

Answer: B.

Option A: Elected representatives make decisions but are not the meaning of the functionaries component.

Option B: Functionaries are the personnel needed to execute assigned work and the question is who controls them.

Option C: This option describes funds rather than functionaries.

Option D: This option describes functions rather than personnel.

Examiner trap: A transferred function without staff control is responsibility without administrative capacity.

MCQ 15

Which item is an own-source or non-grant Panchayat receipt where State law authorises it?

A. A Union Finance Commission grant B. A State grant-in-aid C. A locally levied market fee D. A centrally sponsored scheme transfer

Answer: C.

Option A: A Finance Commission transfer remains a grant even when credited to a Panchayat.

Option B: A grant-in-aid is expressly outside the own-source category.

Option C: A locally authorised and collected fee is a non-grant own-revenue instrument.

Option D: A scheme transfer is intergovernmental funding, not locally raised revenue.

Examiner trap: Classify by source, not by which account finally receives the money.

MCQ 16

Article 243I requires the Governor to constitute:

A. a District Planning Committee annually B. an Election Tribunal before every poll C. a Panchayat Audit Board every three years D. a State Finance Commission every five years

Answer: D.

Option A: The DPC arises under Article 243ZD and is not an annual commission under Article 243I.

Option B: Election-petition forums come from State law rather than this fiscal provision.

Option C: Article 243J concerns accounts and audit but creates no such uniform board.

Option D: The five-year SFC cycle is the constitutional requirement.

Examiner trap: Do not confuse the SFC's fiscal review with the SEC's election function.

MCQ 17

Article 280(3)(bb) asks the Union Finance Commission to recommend measures needed to:

- A. augment a State's Consolidated Fund to supplement Panchayat resources on the basis of SFC recommendations
- B. levy a uniform national property tax for all Gram Panchayats
- C. appoint State Finance Commissioners
- D. audit every Panchayat directly

Answer: A.

Option A: This is the constitutional State-fund augmentation link for Panchayats.

Option B: Local tax authority depends on State law; the Union Finance Commission levies no such national tax.

Option C: The Governor, not the Union Finance Commission, constitutes the SFC.

Option D: Article 280(3)(bb) concerns fiscal recommendations, not direct universal audit.

Examiner trap: The Union Finance Commission supplements the State-local chain; it does not take over SFC or Panchayat functions.

MCQ 18

Which statement correctly distinguishes audit forms?

- A. Social audit is the same as CAG financial certification.
- B. Article 243J permits State law on accounts and audit, while social audit involves community verification of records and outcomes.
- C. Only the Gram Sabha may inspect any government account.
- D. AuditOnline itself constitutionally audits every Panchayat.

Answer: B.

Option A: Social audit and professional financial audit answer different questions and use different authority.

Option B: This preserves both the constitutional audit framework and participatory verification.

Option C: The Constitution does not create such exclusive and unlimited access in this form.

Option D: A digital workflow platform is not itself the constitutional auditor.

Examiner trap: Do not call social audit either a departmental inspection or a CAG audit.

MCQ 19

Which constitutional body controls Panchayat electoral rolls and elections?

- A. Election Commission of India
- B. State Finance Commission
- C. State Election Commission
- D. District Planning Committee

Answer: C.

Option A: The ECI handles elections assigned under Article 324, not ordinary Panchayat polls.

Option B: The SFC reviews local finances.

Option C: Article 243K vests superintendence, direction, and control in the SEC.

Option D: The DPC consolidates district plans and has no election mandate.

Examiner trap: Local-body elections are a frequent ECI-versus-SEC close-option trap.

MCQ 20

State of Goa v Fouziya Imtiaz Shaikh (2021) is most relevant for which proposition?

A. Every local reservation must be fifty percent. B. All delimitation disputes are election petitions. C. The Union Election Commission may supersede a State Election Commission. D. A State Election Commissioner must be independent of the executive and cannot be a serving government official exercising executive office.

Answer: D.

Option A: The case concerned SEC independence, not a universal reservation percentage.

Option B: Article 243O issues are distinct from the appointment-independence holding.

Option C: The judgment strengthened State Election Commission autonomy rather than creating ECI control.

Option D: This states the central institutional holding used for local-election independence.

Examiner trap: Case names must carry holdings; do not attach the triple test to Fouziya.

MCQ 21

Article 243O ordinarily requires a challenge to a completed Panchayat election to be brought through:

A. an election petition under State law B. a reference by the State Finance Commission C. a petition to the Election Commission of India D. a Gram Sabha resolution cancelling the result

Answer: A.

Option A: Article 243O channels election challenges to the prescribed election-petition route.

Option B: The SFC has fiscal functions and cannot adjudicate election validity.

Option C: The ECI is not the forum created for Panchayat election petitions.

Option D: A Gram Sabha has no general constitutional power to annul a Panchayat election.

Examiner trap: The bar on ordinary interference coexists with, rather than abolishes, the statutory election petition.

MCQ 22

Which statement about Article 243M is correct?

A. It applies ordinary Part IX without exception to all Scheduled and tribal areas. B. It excludes specified States and areas, and Parliament may extend Part IX to Scheduled Areas with exceptions and modifications. C. It permanently prohibits Parliament from legislating for any excluded area. D. It makes PESA applicable to Sixth Schedule areas.

Answer: B.

Option A: Part IX itself recognises exclusions rather than universal automatic application.

Option B: This states the exclusion and the parliamentary extension route used for PESA.

Option C: Article 243M contains extension powers, so permanent legislative prohibition is wrong.

Option D: PESA is confined to Fifth Schedule Scheduled Areas.

Examiner trap: Scheduled Areas under the Fifth Schedule and tribal areas under the Sixth Schedule are not interchangeable.

MCQ 23

PESA's special definition of a village is designed around:

A. only the district revenue boundary B. a constituency fixed by the Election Commission of India C. a habitation, hamlet, or group of hamlets comprising a community managing affairs by traditions and customs D. every urban ward adjoining a Scheduled Area

Answer: C.

Option A: A revenue boundary may not capture the community-centred statutory design.

Option B: The ECI does not define PESA villages.

Option C: This is the distinctive community and customary-boundary logic of PESA.

Option D: PESA is a rural Scheduled-Area statute, not an urban-ward law.

Examiner trap: Use the statutory community unit; an administrative village is not automatically the complete answer.

MCQ 24

Which PESA formulation is legally safest?

A. Every Gram Sabha decision is an absolute veto over every project. B. Consultation, recommendation, prior recommendation, and approval are interchangeable. C. PESA applies to all tribal-majority areas regardless of constitutional schedule. D. The legal effect depends on the exact statutory verb, subject, and responsible Gram Sabha or Panchayat.

Answer: D.

Option A: PESA gives strong specified powers but not a universal veto formula.

Option B: The statute deliberately uses different verbs with different legal implications.

Option C: Its direct extension is to Fifth Schedule Scheduled Areas.

Option D: This method prevents overstatement and identifies the relevant clause and actor.

Examiner trap: UPSC can make an option wrong by replacing 'consultation' with 'consent' or 'approval.'

MCQ 25

Under PESA, which proposition is correct?

A. State Panchayat law in Scheduled Areas must respect customary law, social and religious practices, and traditional management of community resources B. Only the district Panchayat may safeguard community resources C. The Gram Sabha has no role in beneficiary identification D. PESA abolishes all State legislation in Scheduled Areas

Answer: A.

Option A: This is a central conformity principle in section 4 of PESA.

Option B: PESA gives community-centred roles and does not reserve all protection to the district tier.

Option C: The statutory scheme includes approval and beneficiary-identification roles.

Option D: PESA requires conforming State law rather than abolishing State legislative operation.

Examiner trap: PESA modifies State Panchayat legislation; it does not replace the whole field with a single central administrative code.

MCQ 26

The District Planning Committee relevant to Panchayat plan consolidation is provided by:

A. Article 243G in Part IX B. Article 243ZD in Part IXA C. Article 280(3)(bb) D. Article 243K

Answer: B.

Option A: Article 243G enables Panchayat plan powers but does not create the DPC.

Option B: Article 243ZD constitutionally provides the district plan-consolidation bridge.

Option C: Article 280(3)(bb) is the Union Finance Commission augmentation clause.

Option D: Article 243K establishes the Panchayat election authority.

Examiner trap: The rural planning answer legitimately cross-links to a Part IXA institution; state the cross-link explicitly.

MCQ 27

Which statement best evaluates eGramSwaraj and AuditOnline?

- A. They automatically transfer all 29 subjects. B. They replace Gram Sabha scrutiny and statutory audit. C. They support planning, accounting, monitoring, and audit workflows but cannot prove substantive devolution or data quality. D. They constitutionally determine State tax rates.

Answer: C.

Option A: Platforms cannot alter Article 243G's State-law devolution requirement.

Option B: Digital systems supplement rather than displace democratic and professional accountability.

Option C: This gives both the official function and the institutional limitation.

Option D: Tax authority remains governed by Article 243H and State law.

Examiner trap: Digital completion is evidence of workflow use, not conclusive evidence of power, consent, or service outcomes.

MCQ 28

What is the most accurate statement about SVAMITVA?

- A. It conclusively determines all rural title disputes under a central property code. B. It is a State Election Commission mapping exercise. C. It automatically creates a uniform Panchayat property tax. D. It supports drone-based survey and property cards in rural inhabited areas, while legal title and tax effects depend on State law.

Answer: D.

Option A: Property and revenue law qualifications prevent a universal conclusive-title claim.

Option B: The scheme is unrelated to SEC election administration.

Option C: Tax consequences require State authorisation and local legal design.

Option D: This states the official tool and the State-law limitation.

Examiner trap: A survey record can improve clarity without having identical title or taxation effects nationwide.

MCQ 29

Kishansing Tomar v Municipal Corporation of Ahmedabad (2006) stands for:

- A. the mandatory importance of timely local-body elections and constitutional continuity B. a nationwide two-tier Panchayat structure C. abolition of State Election Commissions D. automatic OBC reservation without empirical inquiry

Answer: A.

Option A: The Court stressed completion of local elections within the constitutional timetable.

Option B: Tier design comes from Part IX, not this municipal-election case.

Option C: The case reinforces rather than abolishes constitutional election machinery.

Option D: Later reservation cases require empirical compliance and do not follow this proposition.

Examiner trap: The case involved a municipality, but its timely-election reasoning is expressly important to the parallel Panchayat duration rule.

MCQ 30

K. Krishna Murthy v Union of India (2010) is best summarised as holding that:

A. political reservation is identical to reservation in public employment B. backward-class reservation in local bodies is permissible but requires distinct local-political analysis and ordinarily respects the aggregate vertical ceiling C. every backward-class quota must equal the State population share D. women's reservation under Part IX is unconstitutional

Answer: B.

Option A: The Court distinguished political representation from Articles 15(4) and 16(4) contexts.

Option B: This is the precise constitutional contribution without retroactively attributing every later triple-test formulation.

Option C: Population share alone is not the judicial method for local-body OBC reservation.

Option D: The decision did not invalidate the constitutional women's reservation provisions.

Examiner trap: Do not collapse K. Krishna Murthy into the later Gawali formulation; state each case's doctrinal contribution separately.

MCQ 31

What is the first limb of the Vikas Kishanrao Gawali triple test?

A. A Governor's proclamation fixing a statewide quota B. A census that counts only elected representatives C. A dedicated commission conducting contemporaneous rigorous empirical inquiry into backwardness for local-body reservation D. A Union law fixing the same quota in every State

Answer: C.

Option A: A political notification cannot replace the required evidence institution.

Option B: The inquiry concerns backwardness and representation in local bodies, not merely incumbents.

Option C: This is the dedicated-commission and contemporaneous-inquiry requirement.

Option D: Local-body reservation remains State-specific within constitutional limits.

Examiner trap: The triple test is a process plus local-body-wise quantum plus ceiling, not simply a fifty-percent arithmetic rule.

MCQ 32

Rahul Ramesh Wagh (2022) is used to show that:

A. Panchayat elections may wait indefinitely until every reservation dispute ends B. OBC reservation is constitutionally mandatory in all local bodies C. the State Election Commission loses control whenever a commission is appointed D. an OBC-reserved election programme cannot operate without completed triple-test compliance; affected seats proceed as open-category seats until lawful reservation

Answer: D.

Option A: The Court protected the election timetable rather than indefinite postponement.

Option B: Backward-class reservation is enabling, not universally mandatory.

Option C: The SEC's constitutional role continues during reservation compliance.

Option D: This states the compliance consequence enforced in the 2022 Rahul Ramesh Wagh proceedings.

Examiner trap: Use Rahul Ramesh Wagh for the no-reservation-without-triple-test consequence; use Suresh Mahajan for the separate no-indefinite-election-delay rule.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

PYQ 1 - UPSC GS-II 2018, Q15

Exact official wording: "Assess the importance of the Panchayat system in India as a part of local government. Apart from government grants, what sources the Panchayats can look out for financing developmental projects?"

15 marks | 250 words

Key discipline: This is a Mains question; there is no objective answer letter. First assess the institution, then classify non-grant finance. Do not count Finance Commission transfers as own-source revenue.

Model route: Open with Part IX and Article 40. Assess democratic proximity, inclusion, local planning, and accountability, then qualify these gains through uneven devolution. Classify non-grant sources under State-authorised taxes, duties, tolls, fees, user charges, rent and income from Panchayat assets or common resources, assigned State revenues, and State-law-controlled borrowing. Link Article 243H to local discretion and taxpayer accountability. Conclude that grants remain necessary for equalisation, but cannot replace legitimate own-revenue authority and collection capacity.

PYQ 2 - UPSC GS-II 2019, Q13

Exact official wording: "The reservation of seats for women in the institutions of local self-government has had a limited impact on the patriarchal character of the Indian Political Process." Comment.

15 marks | 250 words

Key discipline: Treat "limited impact" as a proposition to evaluate, not an instruction to dismiss reservation. Use Article 243D, gains in access and agenda-setting, continuing proxy control and intersectional barriers, then a qualified verdict.

Model route: Article 243D is a structural entry reform that normalised women in public office and created leadership experience. Its impact is substantive where representatives control meetings, signatures, staff interaction, and budgets. Patriarchy persists through proxy exercise of office, household control, violence, caste hierarchy, weak administrative support, and rotation-related discontinuity. Continuous training, peer networks, independent financial authority, legal action against proxy control, and institutional support can deepen agency. Conclude that reservation has altered access and political imagination, but cannot alone dismantle social power.

PYQ 3 - UPSC GS-II 2020, Q13

Exact official wording: "The strength and sustenance of local institutions in India has shifted from their formative phase of 'Functions, Functionaries and Funds' to the contemporary stage of 'Functionality'. Highlight the critical challenges faced by local institutions in terms of their functionality in recent times."

15 marks | 250 words

Key discipline: Do not merely define the three Fs. Show why their incomplete convergence blocks measurable service outcomes and citizen accountability.

Model route: Article 243G functions remain dependent on State activity mapping; functionaries often answer to line departments; Article 243H revenue authority is narrow, SFC cycles are delayed, and grants are tied. Parallel agencies fragment responsibility. Weak Gram Sabha consequence, limited technical support, data-quality problems, digital exclusion, and poor DPC convergence deepen the gap. Measure functionality through decision power, staff control, predictable discretionary resources, citizen-visible delivery, and public answerability. End with a sequenced reform compact rather than an unfocused demand for more funds.

PYQ 4 - UPSC GS-II 2024

Exact official wording: "Analyse the role of local bodies in providing good governance at local level and bring out the pros and cons merging the rural local bodies with the urban local bodies. (Answer in 150 words)"

10 marks | 150 words

Key discipline: Answer both limbs. Distinguish elected-body merger from shared planning or service arrangements and preserve the Part IX/Part IXA difference.

Model route: Local bodies improve information, participation, planning, delivery, and accountability where powers are real. Merger may help peri-urban water, waste, transport, land use, and revenue coordination, while reducing duplicated structures. It may also dilute Gram Sabha voice, rural representation, PESA safeguards, and distinct rural priorities; tax bases and service standards differ. Prefer DPC consolidation and shared-service arrangements before blanket institutional merger.

PYQ 5 - UPSC Prelims 2025, GS-I, Q91

Exact official wording:

Consider the following statements:

I. Panchayats at the intermediate level exist in all States.

II. To be eligible to be a Member of a Panchayat at the intermediate level, a person should attain the age of thirty years.

III. The Chief Minister of a State constitutes a commission to review the financial position of Panchayats at the intermediate levels and to make recommendations regarding the distribution of net proceeds of taxes and duties, leviable by the State, between the State and Panchayats at the intermediate level.

Which of the statements given above are not correct?

A. I and II only B. II and III only C. I and III only D. I, II and III

Official Set-A answer: D.

Key discipline: I is wrong because a State with population not exceeding twenty lakh may omit the intermediate tier. II is wrong because the protected minimum-age position is twenty-one, not thirty. III is wrong because the Governor constitutes the State Finance Commission.

ORIGINAL MAINS PRACTICE

ORIGINAL MAINS 1 - 10 MARKS

Question: Examine why the Seventy-third Amendment is stronger on democratic form than on devolution. Answer in 150 words.

Model answer (132 words):

Part IX entrenches rural democracy but leaves much governing substance to State choice. Articles 243B-243F guarantee the institutional structure, direct territorial elections, reservations, tenure and disqualification safeguards. Articles 243I and 243K require State Finance and Election Commissions. These provisions reduce the pre-1993 risk of irregular elections and prolonged supersession.

Yet Article 243G says a State legislature may endow powers over Eleventh Schedule matters, while Article 243H makes taxation, assigned revenue, grants and Panchayat Funds dependent on State law. Line departments may retain staff and budgets even after formal subject transfer.

Thus, the Amendment constitutionalised political decentralisation more firmly than administrative and fiscal decentralisation. State variation shows that deeper devolution is legally possible, but not automatic. Binding activity maps, accountable staff and predictable finance are needed to turn protected institutions into effective self-government.

ORIGINAL MAINS 2 - 10 MARKS

Question: Explain the constitutional safeguards for continuity and independence of Panchayat elections. Answer in 150 words.

Model answer (133 words):

Article 243E fixes a five-year Panchayat term and requires an election before expiry or, after premature dissolution, within six months. If the unexpired period is below six months, no election is required merely for that short remainder; a reconstituted body otherwise serves only the balance of the original term.

Article 243K vests electoral rolls and Panchayat elections in the State Election Commission. The State Election Commissioner has High Court Judge-like removal protection, service conditions cannot be varied disadvantageously after appointment, and requested staff must be supplied.

Kishansing Tomar requires timely local elections, while *State of Goa v Fouziya Imtiaz Shaikh* protects SEC independence from executive control. Article 243O limits ordinary interruption and channels result challenges through election petitions. State law may regulate procedure, but cannot defeat the constitutional calendar or the Commission's autonomy.

ORIGINAL MAINS 3 - 15 MARKS

Question: Analyse the constitutional and institutional architecture of Panchayat finance. Answer in 250 words.

Model answer (197 words):

Panchayat finance is a layered State-local system rather than a single grant channel. Article 243H permits State law to authorise local taxes, duties, tolls and fees; assign State-collected revenues; provide grants-in-aid; and constitute Panchayat Funds. Locally raised taxes, fees, user charges and asset income can improve discretion and downward accountability, but their legal availability and rates vary by State.

Article 243I requires the Governor to constitute a State Finance Commission every five years. It reviews State-local tax distribution, assignments, grants and measures to improve Panchayat finances; the report and action explanation are laid before the State legislature. Article 280(3)(bb) then requires the Union Finance Commission to recommend measures to augment State Consolidated Funds for supplementing Panchayat resources on the basis of SFC recommendations.

The architecture weakens when SFCs are delayed, fiscal data are poor, recommendations are ignored, buoyant taxes remain with States, grants are tied, or Panchayats lack collection capacity. Poor jurisdictions also have unequal tax bases.

Reform therefore needs timely SFCs, transparent action reports, predictable untied equalisation, fair State tax assignment, updated local registers, affordable user-charge design and professional collection. Grants secure territorial equity; own revenue secures local discretion. Neither can replace the other.

ORIGINAL MAINS 4 - 15 MARKS

Question: Discuss PESA 1996 as an institutional model of tribal self-government. Answer in 250 words.

Model answer (200 words):

PESA extends Part IX to Fifth Schedule Scheduled Areas with modifications designed around customary community institutions. It requires State Panchayat law to respect customary law, social and religious practices, and traditional management of community resources. Its village may comprise a habitation, hamlet, or group of hamlets whose community manages affairs according to traditions and customs.

The Gram Sabha safeguards traditions, cultural identity, community resources and customary dispute resolution. The statutory design gives roles in approving plans and identifying beneficiaries, consultation before land acquisition and rehabilitation, recommendations in specified minor-mineral decisions, and governance relating to minor forest produce, village markets, money-lending and alienated land.

This model links democracy to territory, livelihood and culture rather than treating tribal communities merely as programme recipients. However, its verbs are not identical: approval, consultation, recommendation and prior recommendation carry different legal effects. State compliance laws, sectoral statutes, records and administrative

behaviour determine real power.

Implementation is weakened by incomplete legal harmonisation, bureaucratic control, resource pressure, inaccessible records and weak follow-up. PESA applies to Fifth Schedule areas, not Sixth Schedule areas or every tribal-majority district. It is therefore an ambitious framework of community-centred self-rule whose promise depends on exact legal compliance and enforceable Gram Sabha authority.

ORIGINAL MAINS 5 - 20 MARKS

Question: Evaluate Panchayati Raj as an instrument of democratic inclusion and accountable development. Answer in 250 words.

Model answer (201 words):

Panchayati Raj relocates representative government, planning and scrutiny to everyday rural life. The Seventy-third Amendment protects elected territorial seats, five-year terms, SC/ST representation and a minimum women's reservation under Article 243D. Gram Sabhas can add direct participation, while PESA adapts this architecture to customary communities in Fifth Schedule areas.

Its development value lies in local information. Article 243G can connect plans for economic development and social justice to the Eleventh Schedule's twenty-nine matters. GPDPs, social audits and district-plan consolidation can align needs, budgets and outcomes. Article 243H own revenue may also create a direct taxpayer-service accountability relationship.

The record is nevertheless uneven. Reservation may not become substantive authority where proxy control, caste exclusion or bureaucratic gatekeeping persists. Functions remain vague, staff answer upward, own revenue is weak, SFC cycles are delayed, grants are tied and parallel agencies fragment responsibility. Digital platforms improve traceability but can reproduce exclusion or formal compliance.

Reform must join activity maps, accountable personnel, predictable untied finance, fair own-source revenue, independent SECs, timely SFCs, accessible records, protected participation and enforceable audit follow-up. State variation means neither universal success nor failure is accurate. Panchayati Raj is democratically transformative where representation is converted into authority, services and public answerability.

ORIGINAL MAINS 6 - 20 MARKS

Question: Design a reform strategy to move Panchayats from the three Fs to measurable functionality. Answer in 250 words.

Model answer (201 words):

Functionality should be tested by whether an elected Panchayat can decide, direct staff, spend predictable resources, deliver services and answer publicly. Reform must therefore be sequenced across institutions rather than reduced to more grants or training.

First, States should publish binding activity maps for devolved Eleventh Schedule work, identify the responsible tier and remove duplicate mandates. Second, relevant staff should be placed under usable Panchayat supervision, with technical pools where specialised capacity cannot be maintained locally. Third, Article 243H authority should combine fair local taxes and fees, assigned State revenues and predictable untied equalisation. State Finance Commissions need a fixed calendar, professional data support and transparent action reports.

Fourth, Gram Sabha notice, accessible records, inclusion and speaking follow-up should be mandatory; social audits must lead to correction or recovery. Fifth, SEC control over the election calendar and staffing should be respected. PESA compliance requires exact statutory verbs and community-resource safeguards. Sixth, GPDPs should connect to Article 243ZD district planning.

Finally, eGramSwaraj, AuditOnline and SVAMITVA should operate with local-language assistance, offline alternatives, data-quality checks and privacy safeguards. The Devolution Index 2024 offers a diagnostic framework, but outcomes must be verified locally. The objective is accountable self-government, not administrative decentralisation in name alone.